

8 Project Teams Update

1. **Cabinet Functioning:** Examine current patterns of leadership and identify next step actions that will strengthen how they work together and how they provide leadership to Asbury.

Note: *Team members include the Cabinet and the President.* If such modification is not feasible, the recommendation is to document the closure of this project and provide a clear rationale for doing so.

2. **Cascading Communication:** Establish a cascading communication process, enabling the Cabinet to promptly relay meeting outcomes and decisions to departments that foster two-way interaction. *Team members include the Cabinet and the President.* Regardless of the outcome of the first action, there is potential for this one to gain traction. *Is there openness to having a conversation to discuss a practical next step for implementing an effective cascading process in the transition?* As with the first project team update, if this is not feasible, the recommendation is to document the closure of this project and provide a clear rationale for doing so.

3. **Connection Opportunities:** Create connection points for the purpose of building and developing relationships across schools, departments, and extension sites. *Team members include Chris Johnson, Ellen Marmon, Greg Mcelyea, MK Graetz, Meredith Fulda, Robbie Danielson.*

There are three actions the team is ready to move forward with if approved.

- a. **Faculty School Meetings:** One of the action steps is to design and implement a structured approach during faculty school meetings to enhance understanding of various seminary departments. We've discussed this idea with the Academic Council, and they are very open to it, as long as these sessions in their meetings are perceived as useful and not forced. The next step is to collaborate with the deans to determine how this could be implemented in each school.
- b. **Community Meetings:** The team has developed a framework for a new kind of administrator, faculty, and staff gathering aimed at creating connection points and the development of relationships across schools, departments, and sites. The rubric framework includes four elements that would be included in all gatherings: a spiritual investment, information updates, relationship building, and professional development. *The team is recommending to schedule one and after reviewing all Seminary calendars is suggesting February 19 from 9:00 - 10:30 am.* This date was vetted by the team as one that would work well considering seminary schedules. Here's a draft of the agenda. The recommended theme is equipping and envisioning people to navigate transitions in a healthy way.
 - **8:45 - Relationship Building** (coffee, snacks, light breakfast)
 - **9:00 - Welcome** (hosted by a non-Cabinet member)

- **9:05 - The 'Why' and Purpose** (share the vision for the new kind of community gathering)
 - **9:12 - Spiritual Investment** (devotional focused on transition)
 - **9:22 - Information Segment** (ask three departments to share what they do, who's on their team, what they're working on, what they want the seminary to know about them, and how the seminary can support them (non-budget) in 2024)
 - **9:42 - Professional Development** (Dr. Tennent shares what healthy transitions look like, practical actions the Seminary and each person can take to contribute to a healthy transition, and an encouragement to be a culture builder in this season of transition.)
 - **10:12 - Q&A**
 - **10:25 - Close**
- c. **Intentional Half Day During the Spring:** One of the action steps is to plan and execute an intentional half-day dedicated to bringing the community together during the spring semester. This event should serve as a connection accelerator, fostering relationships and collaboration among faculty, staff, and administrators. We'll use a similar rubric framework mentioned in (b) above to guide the planning. The recommended theme focuses on Asbury's history, mission, and strategic plan. The working idea is to guide an Asbury scavenger hunt where cross-school, department, and site teams are created and go around campus searching for items that represent something of value to the seminary. The intent is an interactive, engaging, and fun experience for people to share. Teams then meet to learn and discuss the scavenger hunt answers, view photos gathered along the way, and be reminded of their important role in helping the seminary achieve its mission. Additionally, there can be a time of teaching, corporate worship, and prayer. The team has vetted this date as one that would work well, considering seminary schedules. ***The team recommends April 12 from 9:00 am - 1:00 pm.***
- d. **Strategic Info Exchanges:** One of the action steps is to develop a format and framework for departments to learn about each other. The team settled on the idea of leveraging the existing Info Exchanges meetings to accomplish this step, but with increased emphasis by the Cabinet for participation and involvement, ensuring there is a representative from every department, school, and site. Additionally, the team discussed the process of disseminating key information after the meeting to the rest of the seminary. ***We would like to present this idea to the Cabinet and discuss how they can encourage and emphasize the importance of involvement and participation.***

4. **Teamwork:** Define how we'll foster cross school, department, and extension site teamwork and communicate healthily. *Team members include Dan Stephens, Jim Hampton, Kevin Watson, Lacey Craig, Leanne Dzubinski, Wes Custer.*

The primary action item is to develop and communicate a comprehensive definition and framework for healthy communication across all parts of Asbury. Regarding the framework, we're considering using Christine Pohl's approach, which involves embracing gratitude, making and keeping promises, practicing hospitality, and truth-telling. The team is exploring a grassroots approach where each department, school, and site can utilize this framework to create a team covenant. The team is currently in the process of developing a simple document that outlines the framework and provides a script for departments, schools, and sites to use in creating a covenant. Once completed, the recommendation is to present it to the Cabinet for their review and discuss its implementation.

5. **Transparency:** Increase the level of transparency including how information is presented, multiplicity of voices, understanding of department budgets, and the sharing of information with and from the Board. *Team members include Cabinet, President, Chris Kiesling, Ruthanne Reese, Barbara Antrobus, Robin Ferraro.*

There are three things in motion.

- a. **Committee Landing Page:** The team is working on the creation of a landing page that would include the name, function, participants, and how to connect with each faculty and staff committee.
- b. **Raising Topics to the President's Council:** The team has been discussing the clarification needed regarding how departments, schools, and sites connect with the President's Council. Specifically, what types of issues or questions should be raised with the Council? Additionally, once these issues or questions have been discussed, how does the information flow back to departments, schools, and sites?
Could this be an agenda topic for the February meeting of the President's Council?
- c. **Determining How President's Council Meetings Function:** The team debriefed the two fall semester meetings and discussed the need for clarity on how best to structure the meetings moving forward. Specifically, clarify the role of non-Cabinet members. Is it merely to share updates with the Cabinet, or is it to actively participate and contribute their voice and perspective in the conversations? *Could this be an agenda topic for the February meeting of the President's Council?*

6. **Compensation & Benefits:** Reassess, clarify, and communicate Asbury's compensation and benefits philosophy. *Team members include Barbara Antrobus, Bryan Blankenship, Chriss Rooney, Kelly Bixler, Susan Hees, and Tammy Cessna.*

There are two upcoming town hall meetings to discuss compensation, one on January 25 and another on January 31. The project team met last week to conduct a dry run on the slides and presentation. The group will meet again the week of February 5 to begin working on the six steps to plan compensation for a flourishing culture. The first step is to ask employees what means most to them.

7. **Leave Policies:** Review and update the following leave policies: maternity, paternity, family, and mission. *Team members include Barbara Antrobus, Bryan Blankenship, Jeremy Fulda, Jonathan Powers, Paula Hisel, Tracey Farrell.*

Bryan has drafted an updated Parental Leave Policy in the Seminary's standard format and has sent it to legal counsel for review. The team should get feedback in the next week and will meet to discuss the legal review. It will then plan next steps to get feedback from administrators, faculty, and staff.

8. **Spiritual Journey:** Design a spiritual healing and renewal experience for the Asbury community. Included is a rethinking of the chapel strategy. *Team members include Abi Sipe, Chriss Rooney, Fred Long, Jessica LaGrone, Kylie McCormick, Matt Barnes, and Russell Hall.*

The project team is working on a few action items, including the offering of a Healing Community group, communication about the availability of individualized pastoral care and prayer, and a Chapel focus group.

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